

Couture BIRTHS

Luxury limos, jacuzzi dips, Gayatri chants. Boutique birthing catches on as parents take to frill-seeking ways.

| By Damayanti Datta |

The moment you walk into a hospital, an unmistakable "hospital smell" engulfs you. But at Fortis La Femme in Delhi, the aroma of orange blossoms hangs in the air. Expect waiting-room gridlocks? The Nest, Bangalore, with its wait-for-your-turn counters, will take you by surprise. Think twiddling your thumbs, watching the clock tick by, is your lot as a hospital visitor? At the Oyster & Pearl Hospital in Pune you can get busy at the cybercafé or massage parlour. Worried about commuting to and from the hospital? At The Cradle, Bangalore, a luxury car will be at your beck and call. Hospitals are not hotels, you always thought, no matter how friendly the staff and cheery the ambience. But new generation birth centres are turning that conventional wisdom upside down.

Pamper the patient is the buzzword. "It was not just comfortable, they made me feel very special," recalls Namrata Mann of Delhi, who delivered her baby at La Femme last year. "That's the refrain from most women who go through the boutique experience," points out Rohit M.A., one of the directors at The Cradle, Bangalore. And why not? Giving birth is not exactly just another day in a woman's life. A study in the March 2007 issue of the journal, *Birth*, reports that women have long-term memory of their birth experience and it affects their self-esteem later. "Even 10 years back, women had lit-

tle say in choosing when, where and how they would give birth," says Arindam Banerjee, general manager of the newly set up Columbia Asia in Kolkata, the only boutique birthing facility in the east. "Today's women are more assertive, often economically independent, have more choices and want this experience to be special."

That makes perfect business sense in a country where maternity is the second largest reason for hospitalisation. According to a CII-McKinsey report (Healthcare in India, 2002), Indian hospitals get about 54.5 million would-be mothers a year. In this Rs 6,000-crore market, over Rs 2,500 crore comes from the affluent classes. By 2012, the market is expected to grow to Rs 11,000 crore, with the upper crust contributing over Rs 6,400 crore. In a city like Bangalore, more than 400 babies are said to be born every day. About 15 per cent of the parents can afford a couture birth.

Around 2004-05, there were just two such facilities in the country—The Cradle floated by the Apollo Group and La Femme by Fortis. But by 2009, it's hard to count them on your fingers: Cradle has rolled out across Bangalore, Gurgaon, Kozhikode; the Wockhardt Hospitals Group has set up The Nest in Bangalore. And, what's more, existing hospitals have started adding designer "birthing suites"—Hiranandani and Lilavati hospitals in Mumbai, Oyster & Pearl Hospital in Pune, Columbia Asia in Kolkata and Bangalore, Moolchand Hospital in Delhi to name a few.

